

Word family: **safe / safer / safest / safely / safety / unsafe / safeguard**

Base word: safe

Part of speech: mainly **adjective**, also **noun**

Related forms:

* **safe** (adj.) — 安全的；沒有危險的；穩妥的；保險的

* **safe** (n.) — 保險箱

* **safely** (adv.) — 安全地

* **safety** (n.) — 安全；安全措施

* **unsafe** (adj.) — 不安全的；有危險的

* **safeguard** (n./v.) — 保障；保護措施；保護

Useful expressions / extensions:

* **safe place**

* **safe journey**

* **safe to use / eat / drink**

* **safe from**

* **safe and sound**

* **play it safe**

* **better safe than sorry**

* **safe bet**

* **safe choice**

* **safe option**

* **safe seat**

* **safe pair of hands**

* **on the safe side**

* **in safe hands**

* **safe deposit box**

* **safety net**

* **safety measure**

* **safeguard against**

Meaning in this passage

> Those presents were perfectly fine, but they were a little **safe** and predictable.

Here, **safe** does **not** mean physically protected from danger.

It means:

**unlikely to cause offence or fail, but also not very adventurous, original, or surprising — 保守

的；穩陣的；不冒險的**

The gifts were acceptable and sensible, but not especially creative or personal.

中文翻譯：

那些禮物當然沒有問題，但都比較**穩陣 / 保守**，也比較可以預料。

So here:

safe = 選擇風險很低，不容易出錯，但亦不算大膽、特別或有創意

1. **safe (安全的；沒有危險的) — 安全的**

This is the core meaning.

Practice 1

> This neighbourhood is generally **safe** at night.

這個社區晚上一般都很**安全**。

Practice 2

> The children are **safe** now.

孩子們現在已經**安全**了。

Practice 3

> Is it **safe** to swim here?

在這裏游泳**安全嗎**？

MCQ-ready definition:

safe = not likely to cause or suffer harm, injury, or danger

中文：

不容易造成或遭受傷害、危險或損失的

2. **safe from something — 免受……傷害；不受……威脅**

Practice 1

> The animals are **safe from hunters** here.

這裏的動物**不受獵人威脅**。

Practice 2

> Keep the documents somewhere **safe from fire**.

把文件放在一個**不容易受火災影響的安全地方**。

MCQ-ready definition:

safe from X = protected from being harmed or affected by X

3. **safe to use / eat / drink — 可以安全使用 / 食用 / 飲用**

Practice 1

> Is this water **safe to drink**?

這些水**可以安全飲用嗎**？

Practice 2

> The equipment is **safe to use**.

這件設備**可以安全使用**。

MCQ-ready definition:

safe to do = unlikely to cause harm if used, eaten, drunk, or done

4. **safe place — 安全地方**

Practice 1

> We found a **safe place** to wait.

我們找到一個**安全的地方**等候。

Practice 2

> Keep your passport in a **safe place**.

把護照放在**安全的地方**。

MCQ-ready definition:

safe place = a location where a person or object is protected from danger or loss

5. **safe journey / safe trip — 一路平安；旅途安全**

Practice 1

> Have a **safe journey**.

祝你**一路平安**。

Practice 2

> I hope you have a **safe trip** home.

希望你回家**旅途平安**。

MCQ-ready definition:

safe journey/trip = a journey completed without harm or serious problems

6. **safe and sound — 平安無事；安然無恙**

A very common fixed expression.

Practice 1

> They arrived home **safe and sound**.

他們**平安無事**地回到家。

Practice 2

> The missing child was found **safe and sound**.

失蹤的孩子被找到時**安然無恙**。

MCQ-ready definition:

****safe and sound = completely safe and unharmed****

7. ****safe (穩妥的 ; 不冒險的) — 穩陣的 ; 保守的****

This is the exact sense used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original context

> The gifts were a little ****safe**** and predictable.

那些禮物有點****穩陣 / 保守****，也比較可以預料。

Practice 2

> Choosing black is a ****safe**** option.

選黑色是一個比較****穩陣的選擇****。

Practice 3

> His speech was competent but too ****safe****.

他的演講算是穩妥，但太****保守、不夠大膽****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****safe = unlikely to fail or offend, but not bold, original, or risky****

中文：

****風險低、不容易出錯，但亦不算大膽或有創意的****

8. ****safe choice / safe option — 穩陣選擇 ; 保險做法****

Practice 1

> A gift card is a ****safe choice****.

禮品卡是一個比較****穩陣的選擇****。

Practice 2

> We chose the ****safe option**** and booked the earlier flight.

我們選擇了**較保險的方案**，預訂較早的航班。

MCQ-ready definition:

safe choice/option = a choice with relatively little risk of going wrong

9. **play it safe — 採取穩妥做法；不冒險**

Practice 1

> We decided to **play it safe** and leave early.

我們決定**穩陣一點**，提早出發。

Practice 2

> He always **plays it safe** when investing.

他投資時總是**採取保守做法**。

MCQ-ready definition:

play it safe = choose the least risky course of action

中文：

選擇最不冒險、最穩妥的做法

10. **better safe than sorry — 小心駛得萬年船；寧可小心一點**

Practice 1

> Take an umbrella—**better safe than sorry**.

帶把傘吧，**小心一點總好過後悔**。

Practice 2

> I backed up the files twice. **Better safe than sorry**.

我把檔案備份了兩次，**有備無患總比後悔好**。

MCQ-ready definition:

****better safe than sorry = it is wiser to be cautious now than regret a problem later****

11. ****on the safe side — 為安全起見；穩妥起見****

Practice 1

> Leave ten minutes early ****to be on the safe side****.

為了****穩妥起見****，提早十分鐘出發。

Practice 2

> Take an extra copy, just ****to be on the safe side****.

為了****保險起見****，多帶一份副本。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****on the safe side = taking extra precautions to reduce risk****

12. ****safe bet — 很有把握的選擇；穩妥判斷****

A figurative sense.

Practice 1

> It's a ****safe bet**** that the train will be crowded.

可以****很有把握地說****火車會很擠迫。

Practice 2

> A simple black jacket is usually a ****safe bet****.

簡單的黑色外套通常是個****穩陣選擇****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****safe bet = something very likely to be successful, true, or suitable****

中文：

****成功或正確機會很高的選擇 / 判斷****

13. **safe pair of hands — 穩可靠的人；值得信任的人**

Especially BrE.

Practice 1

> She's a **safe pair of hands** for the project.

她是這個項目上一個**很穩可靠的人選**。

Practice 2

> They wanted a **safe pair of hands** to manage the team.

他們想找一個**穩健可靠的人**管理團隊。

MCQ-ready definition:

a safe pair of hands = a reliable person who can be trusted to handle responsibility well

14. **in safe hands — 由可靠的人照顧 / 處理**

Practice 1

> Don't worry—the children are **in safe hands**.

別擔心，孩子們現在由**可靠的人照顧**。

Practice 2

> Your account is **in safe hands** with our team.

你的帳戶由我們團隊處理，**可以放心**。

MCQ-ready definition:

in safe hands = being looked after or managed by someone reliable

15. **safe seat — 穩固議席；勝算很高的席位**

A political/electoral term.

Practice 1

> The party has held the seat for many years, making it a **safe seat**.

該黨多年來一直保有這個議席，因此它被視為一個**相對穩固的議席**。

Practice 2

> Candidates often campaign differently in **safe seats** and competitive seats.

候選人在**穩固議席**和競爭激烈的議席中，競選方式可能不同。

MCQ-ready definition:

safe seat = an electoral seat that a party or candidate has historically won by a comfortable margin

16. **safe** (棒球：安全上壘) — 安全上壘

A sports-specific sense.

Practice 1

> The runner was called **safe**.

跑者被判**安全上壘**。

Practice 2

> He reached first base **safe**.

他成功**安全上到一壘**。

MCQ-ready definition:

safe = baseball/softball: having reached a base without being put out

17. **safe** (noun：保險箱) — 保險箱

A major separate noun sense.

Practice 1

> The jewellery is kept in a **safe**.

珠寶放在**保險箱**裏。

Practice 2

> He locked the documents in the **safe**.

他把文件鎖進**保險箱**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****safe = a strong locked metal box or cabinet used to protect valuables****

18. ****safe deposit box — 保險箱 / 銀行保管箱****

Practice 1

> She keeps the documents in a ****safe deposit box**** at the bank.

她把文件放在銀行的**保管箱**裏。

Practice 2

> The jewellery was stored in a ****safe deposit box****.

珠寶存放在**銀行保險箱**中。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****safe deposit box = a secure locked box, usually at a bank, for storing valuables****

19. ****safely — 安全地****

Practice 1

> They arrived ****safely****.

他們**安全地**到達了。

Practice 2

> Store the chemicals ****safely****.

把化學品**安全地**存放好。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****safely = in a way that avoids harm or danger****

20. ****safety (安全) — 安全 ; 安全狀況****

Practice 1

> Passenger ****safety**** is our priority.

乘客****安全****是我們的首要考慮。

Practice 2

> The building was closed for ****safety**** reasons.

大樓因****安全原因****關閉。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****safety = the state of being protected from danger or harm****

21. ****safety measure / precaution — 安全措施 / 預防措施****

Practice 1

> Wearing a helmet is an important ****safety measure****.

戴頭盔是一項重要的****安全措施****。

Practice 2

> The company introduced additional ****safety precautions****.

公司增加了額外的****安全預防措施****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****safety measure = an action or rule designed to reduce danger****

22. ****safety net — 安全網 ; 保障機制****

Literal and figurative.

Practice 1

> The workers used a **safety net** below the platform.

工人在平台下方使用**安全網**。

Practice 2

> Savings can provide a financial **safety net**.

儲蓄可以提供一個財務**安全網 / 保障**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****safety net = literally a protective net; figuratively, a system or resource that protects against serious loss****

23. **safety valve — 安全閥 ; 紓壓出口**

Literal and figurative.

Practice 1

> The machine has a **safety valve**.

機器有一個**安全閥**。

Practice 2

> Exercise can act as a **safety valve** for stress.

運動可以成為釋放壓力的**出口**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****safety valve = literally a device that releases dangerous pressure; figuratively, a way to release emotional or social pressure****

24. **unsafe — 不安全的 ; 危險的**

Practice 1

> The bridge is **unsafe**.

這座橋**不安全**。

Practice 2

> It's **unsafe to drive** in these conditions.

在這種情況下駕駛**很危險**。

MCQ-ready definition:

unsafe = likely to cause harm, injury, or danger

25. **safeguard (verb : 保護 ; 保障) — 保障 ; 保護**

Practice 1

> We need to **safeguard children's privacy**.

我們需要**保障兒童私隱**。

Practice 2

> The rules are designed to **safeguard workers**.

這些規則旨在**保障工人**。

MCQ-ready definition:

safeguard = protect someone or something from harm, damage, or loss

26. **safeguard (noun : 保障措施) — 保障 ; 保護措施**

Practice 1

> The system includes several **safeguards**.

這個系統設有多項**保障措施**。

Practice 2

> Strong legal **safeguards** are needed.

需要有健全的法律**保障機制**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****safeguard = a rule, system, or measure that protects against danger or abuse****

Important distinction 1: ****safe vs secure****

****safe****

emphasizes freedom from harm or danger.

****secure****

often emphasizes protection against loss, attack, unauthorized access, or instability.

> a safe place for children

對兒童安全的地方

> a secure password

安全性高的密碼

There is overlap, but collocations differ.

Important distinction 2: ****safe vs harmless****

****safe****

not likely to cause harm in a particular use/situation.

****harmless****

does not cause harm.

> This medicine is safe when used correctly.

正確使用時是安全的。

> The insect is harmless.

這種昆蟲無害。

Important distinction 3: **safe vs careful**

safe

describes the situation/choice.

careful

describes someone's behaviour.

> a safe route

安全路線

> a careful driver

小心駕駛的司機

Important distinction 4: **safe vs conservative**

This matters directly in your passage.

safe

low-risk, unlikely to go wrong.

conservative

can mean cautious/traditional in many non-political contexts.

> a safe gift

穩陣的禮物

> a conservative design

較傳統保守的設計

In your passage, **safe** is milder and more natural.

Important distinction 5: **safe vs boring**

safe

not adventurous.

boring

not interesting.

A gift can be safe without being boring.

The speaker's old gifts were simply predictable and low-risk.

Important distinction 6: **safe vs predictable**

safe

focuses on low risk.

predictable

focuses on lack of surprise.

Your passage uses both because they are related but not identical:

> safe **and** predictable

= **穩陣，而且容易估到**

Important distinction 7: **play it safe vs be safe**

be safe

be free from danger.

play it safe

deliberately choose the least risky approach.

> Stay safe.

注意安全。

> Let's play it safe.

我們穩陣一點。

Important distinction 8: ****safe bet is usually figurative****

> It's a safe bet that she'll come.

This does not normally mean actual gambling.

It means:

****很有把握的判斷****

Important distinction 9: ****safe pair of hands vs safe hands****

****a safe pair of hands****

a reliable person.

****in safe hands****

being looked after by reliable people.

> She's a safe pair of hands.

她本人很可靠。

> The project is in safe hands.

項目交給可靠的人處理。

Important distinction 10: ****safe adjective vs safe noun****

Adjective

> The money is safe.

錢很安全。

Noun

> The money is in the safe.

錢在保險箱裏。

Tiny grammar change, totally different meaning.

Important distinction 11: **safety vs security**

safety

protection from accidents and harm.

security

protection from threats, theft, attack, or unauthorized access.

> road safety

道路安全

> airport security

機場保安

Important distinction 12: **safeguard vs safety**

safety

state of being safe.

safeguard

specific thing/action that protects.

> improve safety

改善安全性

> introduce safeguards

引入保障措施

Family-extension note

****Safe**** has several strong modern branches:

1. ****free from danger****

- * safe place
- * safe to use
- * safe from harm

2. ****low-risk / conservative****

- * safe choice
- * safe option
- * play it safe

3. ****high probability****

- * safe bet

4. ****reliable person/management****

- * safe pair of hands
- * in safe hands

5. ****sports****

- * safe at base

6. ****noun: secure container****

- * a safe
- * safe deposit box

7. ****family extensions****

- * safely
- * safety
- * unsafe

* safeguard

For your passage, the key semantic jump is:

physically free from danger → figuratively free from social or practical risk

A **safe gift** is one that is unlikely to go wrong, but may also feel less original.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
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safe	安全的	free from danger	
safe from X	免受 X 傷害	protected from	
safe to use/eat/drink	可安全使用 / 食用	low harm	
safe place	安全地方	protected location	
safe journey	一路平安	safe travel	
safe and sound	安然無恙	unharmed	
safe (choice)	穩陣的；保守的	low-risk	
safe choice/option	穩陣選擇	unlikely to fail	
play it safe	穩陣行事	avoid risk	
better safe than sorry	有備無患	caution first	
on the safe side	為保險起見	extra caution	
safe bet	很有把握的選擇	highly likely	
safe pair of hands	穩可靠的人	reliable person	
in safe hands	由可靠的人處理	well looked after	
safe seat	穩固議席	historically secure seat	
safe (baseball)	安全上壘	not out	
safe (noun)	保險箱	secure container	
safe deposit box	銀行保管箱	secure storage	
safely	安全地	without harm	
safety	安全	protected state	
safety measure	安全措施	risk reduction	
safety net	安全網；保障	fallback protection	
safety valve	安全閥 / 紓壓出口	pressure release	
unsafe	不安全的	dangerous	
safeguard (v.)	保障；保護	protect	
safeguard (n.)	保障措施	protective measure	

For your original sentence

> Those presents were perfectly fine, but they were a little **safe** and predictable.

Here:

safe = 穩陣、保守、不容易送錯，但亦欠缺一點驚喜或個人特色

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 那些禮物當然沒有問題，但都比較**穩陣**，也比較可以預料。

Here **「安全的」** would be too literal. The speaker is talking about **risk in gift choice**, not physical danger.